

RAIN Process

The following exercise was introduced to my husband and me by Micki Fine during the MBSR class in 2010. I have edited it for our purposes. You might recognize in it the foundation for the FAITH process we use in every KF meeting.

Recognize that discomfort or suffering is present. You can pause for a moment and acknowledge that it is there, almost like giving it a little nod of greeting. “I see you there, suffering.” This is choosing to look instead of ignoring or turning away.

Allow the suffering to be present as best you can. You might start by breathing with the suffering, coexisting with it. Notice any struggle to push it away, deny, or control it. Then instead of bracing away from the suffering, try softening toward it. As best you can, let go of the struggle to change the suffering. Can you allow it be present in your space, even for a few moments? If the struggle is intense you might simply notice and allow the struggle.

Investigate. Try approaching the suffering with kindly curiosity. What is here? Can you move beyond judgment words like “bad” and “pain” to descriptive words like “tension,” “aching,” “numb,” “disappointment,” or “anger?” If you are exploring an emotion or thought, bring your attention to the body and notice where you feel the emotion in the body. You might say to yourself, “This is what anger feels like”. Gently maintain your attention on the sensations elicited by the emotion. If the sensations are intense you can move your attention to a place in the body that you do not feel the emotion and return to where you feel the emotion after settling yourself a bit.

Non-Identify. Experiment with noticing that the suffering is not you. You might remind yourself that you are not alone in your suffering, that all creatures suffer. Also, by choosing to focus on the body, the story and drama in the mind are minimized and we can begin to let the emotion move through us instead of getting caught up in the story or judgment.

With each part of this process, practice gentleness and patience.

(Attributed by Micki Fine to Michelle McDonald Smith)